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## Intelligence Briefing

**Europe/Africa**

May 23, 2026

### ■ AI-GENERATED CONTENT

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## EXECUTIVE SUMMARY (BLUF)

**Russia's war in Ukraine is at a critical juncture: Ukrainian defenses hold the frontline, but the Kremlin remains committed to seizing Donetsk and Luhansk despite massive losses, while concurrently escalating nuclear posture through joint exercises with Belarus. Meanwhile, Iran's ongoing blockade of the Strait of Hormuz threatens European energy security, prompting NATO to consider escort operations, as negotiations stall over uranium enrichment and strait governance.**

## KEY DEVELOPMENTS

- Ukraine's defensive lines hold and achieve gains; Russia suffers heavy casualties (~1,000/day) but sticks to maximalist war aims.
- Russia conducts unannounced strategic nuclear exercise with Belarus, deepening military integration and raising escalation risk for NATO.
- Iran's Strait of Hormuz blockade persists; NATO discusses escort operations starting July, while negotiations remain split on uranium and strait control.
- Ukraine conducts deep strikes into Russian defense industry and oil infrastructure, including near Moscow.
- South Korea likely to join US-led maritime coalition after Iranian attack on its vessel in the Strait of Hormuz.

## RUSSIA-UKRAINE CONFLICT

Ukraine continues to stabilize the frontline and has made territorial gains following Russia's loss of Starlink access in February 2026. NATO Secretary General Rutte confirmed Ukraine's progress, while ISW assesses that Russian forces are suffering approximately 1,021 casualties per day. Bloomberg reports that senior Kremlin officials view the war as a 'dead end,' yet President Putin remains committed to fully seizing Donetsk and Luhansk oblasts by end of 2026. Ukraine's 'Fortress Belt' of large cities remains the cornerstone of its defense; if Russia captures this critical terrain, it could launch deeper offensives into vulnerable areas. Ukrainian forces struck deep into Russia, hitting the Angstrom semiconductor plant and Moscow Oil Refinery, disrupting defense industry logistics.

### **Sources:**

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 22, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 20, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 18, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 17, 2026
- Ukraine's Fortress Belt: The Key to Sustaining the Frontline

## **RUSSIAN NUCLEAR POSTURE AND BELARUS INTEGRATION**

Russia and Belarus completed a two-stage combined nuclear exercise on May 21, involving strategic forces, ICBM launches, and the deployment of nuclear munitions to Belarus. President Putin and Lukashenko presided, and future 'Union Shield' exercises in 2027 may include a nuclear component for the first time. This exercise—unannounced and conducted earlier than typical annual drills—is designed to posture strength and distract from battlefield weaknesses, while highlighting Russia's de facto absorption of Belarus. Moscow is also using Belarusian territory to station nuclear weapons, escalating the security threat to NATO's eastern flank.

### **Sources:**

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026

## **IRAN AND STRAIT OF HORMUZ: IMPACT ON EUROPEAN ENERGY SECURITY**

Negotiations between the US and Iran have made 'slight progress' but remain deadlocked on Iran's highly enriched uranium stockpile and control over the Strait of Hormuz. Iran continues to institutionalize a protection racket, requiring vessels to obtain 'permission' to transit the strait—a de facto claim of sovereignty. The US canceled a planned strike after regional mediation, but Trump remains ready for large-scale operations. South Korea is considering joining the US-led Maritime Freedom Construct coalition after Iran's attack on a South Korean-owned vessel. A senior NATO official reports that several NATO countries support an escort plan starting July if the blockade persists, but unanimous approval is lacking. Iran is using the ceasefire to reconstitute drone and missile capabilities, threatening maritime security and European energy imports.

### **Sources:**

- Iran Update Special Report, May 22, 2026

- Iran Update Special Report, May 21, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 20, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 19, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 18, 2026
- Korean Peninsula Update, May 19, 2026

## OUTLOOK

*The next weeks will see continued attrition in Ukraine with no imminent breakthrough, while Russian nuclear posturing may increase pressure on European allies. Iran's blockade will likely drive NATO toward a formal escort mission by July, but unresolved nuclear demands risk militarized escalation in the Persian Gulf.*

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